

60 Samuel

The last of the judges and a faithful prophet, who anointed Israel's first two kings.

Samuel was born in answer to his mother Hannah's prayer and grew up serving God at the tabernacle in Shiloh. As a boy he heard the LORD call him by name, and all Israel came to know him as a prophet. He called Israel away from idols and judged the nation all his life, traveling a yearly circuit of towns. When the people demanded a king, Samuel warned them and prayed, and then he anointed Saul. When Saul disobeyed, Samuel rebuked him, and later he anointed young David. Samuel bridged the time of the judges and the time of the kings. Scripture remembers him beside Moses as a man who prayed for his people.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Shemuel</i> ; "asked of the LORD" (1 Samuel 1:20)
Family	Son of Elkanah and Hannah; sons Joel and Abiah (1 Samuel 1:19–20; 8:2)
When	Born c. 1100 BC (rough); died late in Saul's reign
Roles	Prophet, judge, and minister before the LORD (1 Samuel 2:18; 3:20; 7:15)
Key places	Ramah, Shiloh, Mizpeh, Bethel, Gilgal, Bethlehem
Key people	Hannah, Eli, Saul, David
Main passages	1 Samuel 1–25; 28
New Testament	Acts 3:24; 13:20; Hebrews 11:32

"And Samuel grew, and the LORD was with him, and did let none of his words fall to the ground."

1 Samuel 3:19, KJV

The life of Samuel

Dates are rough: Samuel born c. 1100 BC; Saul's reign c. 1050–1010 BC.

c. 1100 BC <i>Infancy</i>	● Asked of the LORD Hannah's prayed-for son is brought to Eli at Shiloh and ministers before the LORD. <i>1 Samuel 1:20–28; 2:11, 18</i>
Childhood	● Called by name God calls Samuel by night. He answers, "Speak; for thy servant heareth," and receives a hard message about Eli's house. <i>1 Samuel 3:1–18</i>
Growing up	● Known as a prophet All Israel from Dan to Beersheba knows Samuel is established as a prophet of the LORD. <i>1 Samuel 3:19–4:1</i>
Twenty years on	● Victory at Mizpeh Samuel calls Israel to put away foreign gods. He prays, the LORD thunders against the Philistines, and he sets up Ebenezer. <i>1 Samuel 7:2–14</i>
All his life	● Judges Israel Each year he travels a circuit to Bethel, Gilgal and Mizpeh, then returns home to Ramah. <i>1 Samuel 7:15–17</i>
c. 1050 BC <i>Old age</i>	● Anoints Saul His sons take bribes, and the elders ask for a king. Samuel warns them, then anoints Saul. <i>1 Samuel 8:1–10:25</i>
Saul's reign	● Rebukes and grieves He rebukes Saul for an unlawful sacrifice and for sparing Agag: "to obey is better than sacrifice." <i>1 Samuel 13:8–14; 15:1–35</i>
Late in Saul's reign	● Anoints David and dies He anoints Jesse's youngest son, David, and later shelters him at Ramah. All Israel mourns his death. <i>1 Samuel 16:1–13; 19:18–24; 25:1</i>

Key activities

After Samuel's death, Saul asks a medium at Endor to bring him up, and "Samuel" speaks to Saul (1 Samuel 28:3–20). Many Christians believe God truly allowed Samuel to appear; others think it was a deception or a spirit posing as him.

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- I Ministered from childhood.** As a boy he served before the LORD at Shiloh, girded with a linen ephod. *1 Samuel 2:18*

 - 2 Listened to God.** He answered God's call and told Eli the hard message in full. *1 Samuel 3:10–18*

 - 3 Called Israel to repent.** He urged them to put away Baalim and Ashtaroth and serve the LORD only. *1 Samuel 7:3–4*

 - 4 Prayed for the nation.** At Mizpeh he cried to the LORD for Israel, and the LORD heard him. *1 Samuel 7:5–10*

 - 5 Set up Ebenezer.** He named the stone, saying, "Hitherto hath the LORD helped us." *1 Samuel 7:12*

 - 6 Judged Israel all his life.** He rode a yearly circuit and built an altar at Ramah. *1 Samuel 7:15–17*

 - 7 Warned against a king.** He told the people how a king would take their sons, daughters, fields and flocks. *1 Samuel 8:10–18*

 - 8 Anointed Saul.** He poured oil on Saul's head and kissed him. *1 Samuel 10:1*

 - 9 Defended his integrity.** At Gilgal he asked whose ox or ass he had taken, and the people said he had defrauded no one. *1 Samuel 12:1–5*

 - 10 Kept praying.** "God forbid that I should sin against the LORD in ceasing to pray for you." *1 Samuel 12:23*

 - 11 Rebuked Saul.** He declared that God had rejected Saul as king because Saul had rejected God's word. *1 Samuel 15:22–28*

 - 12 Anointed David.** He learned that "the LORD looketh on the heart" and anointed Jesse's youngest son. *1 Samuel 16:6–13*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Samuel.

Old Testament

1 Samuel 1-25	The main account; his death in 25:1 and 28:3
1 Chronicles 6:27-28, 33	Listed among the Levites of Kohath
1 Chronicles 9:22; 29:29	"Samuel the seer" and his book
Psalm 99:6; Jeremiah 15:1	Named with Moses as one who prayed
2 Chronicles 35:18	No Passover like Josiah's since Samuel's days

New Testament

Acts 3:24; 13:20	"All the prophets from Samuel"; judges "until Samuel"
Hebrews 11:32	Named among the heroes of faith
Echo: Luke 2:52	Jesus grows in favour, as Samuel did (1 Samuel 2:26)
Tradition	The Talmud credits him with Judges and Ruth; Scripture does not say

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Samuel set up after the victory at Mizpeh, and what did he say (1 Samuel 7:12)?
2. *Understand:* Samuel warned against a king, yet anointed Saul and kept praying. What does that show about his heart?
3. *Apply:* Samuel said failing to pray for others would be sin (1 Samuel 12:23). Whom will you commit to pray for this week?
4. *Apply:* "The LORD looketh on the heart" (1 Samuel 16:7). Where do you judge by outward looks, and how could you look deeper?